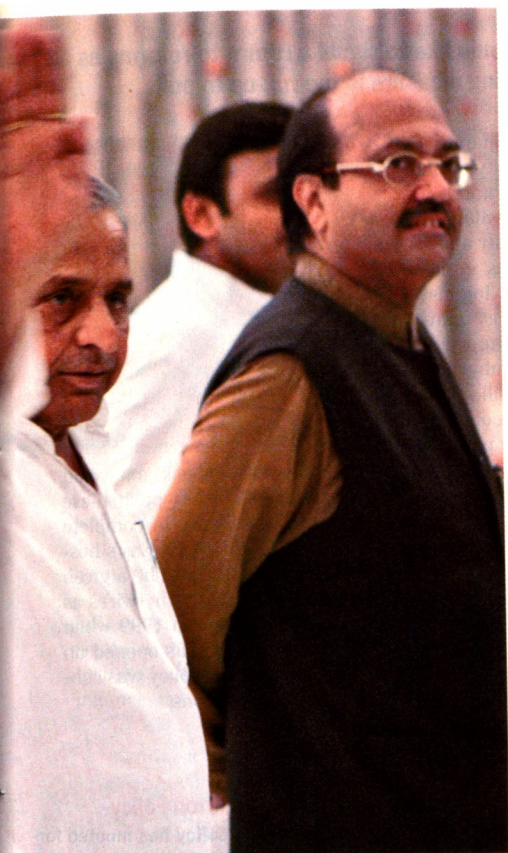




FINE QUARTET: Sonia, Rahul (left), Mulayam and Amar Singh have sunk their differences and seem to work in perfect unison

Our friends in the Left Front should ponder over the company they are forced to keep because of miscalculations by their general secretary.

When I look at the composition of the opportunistic group opposed to us, it is clear to me that the clash today is between two alternative visions of India's future.

Excerpts from PM's speech in the Lok Sabha

And the prime minister, who was the least political at a time when politics for the comrades was pure harlotry, couldn't afford—or didn't have the mandate—to antagonise the tormentor. He suffered in silence as the rusty anti-imperialism of the Marxists dominated the day. He wanted the deal, somehow, but he didn't have the conviction to stand by something—perhaps the only thing—he hoped would be his legacy. It was as if the meek-est had inherited the office. Then one fateful day....

On July 22, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, as he stood in the House with the poise of a warrior king, it was unlikely that he would have recognised the other prime minister. More likely, Manmohan Rearmed may not even want to know that non-entity from history. It is not the time to be distracted by the past, and if there is any resemblance between the two, it is accidental—an adjective that Manmohan's biography won't be able to avoid. At the moment, though, enthralled Manmohanites are struggling to find new adjectives to mythify his heroism. Look around and see the sweep of his triumph, even if you find it hard to discount the moral cost of the operation. Comrade Prakash Karat, till the other day the omnipotent general secretary who fantasised about having an eternal mandate to rule India by proxy, was elsewhere, plotting a purge in his own party. The apparatchik lost the day because of his ideological overreach. The prime minister took particular care to separate the "miscalculating" general secretary from friends like Jyoti Basu and Harkishan Singh Surjeet to emphasise the "betrayal" by a traditional ally at the Centre.

It was his day of independence from the Marxist zealots who held India to ransom. Manmohan has always had a privileged place in middle class India. On July 22, by the final act of exorcism that brought an end to the Red Evil, he has taken complete copyright of it. Idolised in the drawing rooms of middle India and celebrated in the marketplace (the Sensex went down by 30 per cent in the run-up to the vote but it was up by 8-10 per cent during the debate), he is no longer the prisoner prime minister, at least for a while in public perception. And surprisingly, converts and believers alike refuse to see the moral cost of Singh Shining. Shibu Soren? Those wads of currency notes in the well of the House? Ah well, stuff happens in a democracy like India, so you are being asked to suspend your moral revulsion—keep it for another day. Remember, this despite the fact that it was a few unscrupulous individuals but not any party that made him the winner in a nail-biting finale.

More than a winner. The vote finally made him a conviction politician. For a long time, as a victim